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PSYCHOLOGY CONFERENCE



Redefining Student Mental
Health and Wellbeing

RETHINK. REFRAME. REDEFINE.

Conference Abstracts

Redefining Student Mental Health and Wellbeing

Saturday, 19 September 2026 · University of Birmingham Dubai



In partnership with the UoBD Psychology
Society

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Conference contact: uobdpsychologyconference@contacts.bham.ac.uk

Who's in the Driver's Seat: Exploring Self-Knowledge in the Age of Tech

09:00-10:00

Dr. Chasity O'Connell

- Professor of Practice, American University of Sharjah
- Clinical Director, Thrive Centre for Wellbeing, Dubai

Abstract

We are in an age of something unprecedented and almost paradoxical; our algorithms seem to know us better than we know ourselves. They have mapped our patterns, know what we like, anticipate our needs and wants, and actively shape what appears on our screens (often without us noticing).

Now, I am not an Tech Scientist or AI researcher. However, I am interested in how AI and technology are impacting us in terms of our development and well-being. I've seen clients and students rattle off sophisticated concepts in psychology and mental health. However, when it comes to understanding or experiencing that concept, there is a gap. However, when it comes to collecting information vs understanding a concept, there is a gap. Now, educational institutions try to help us move from knowing to understanding for major content areas, but there really isn't a curriculum for understanding yourself. After all, we are in the "information age" (ironically, not the "knowledge age").

This talk will explore ways to deepen and interact with our own self-knowledge and self-awareness. Using emotional intelligence as a framework, we will explore what emotional intelligence is, how it helps us build self-knowledge and self-awareness as we engage with technology. While we may fantasize about life before smartphones, social media and AI, we are past the point of turning back. And so, the idea is to help us feel a deeper sense of self-fortification so that we can attempt to maintain our spot in the driver's seat when driving these tech highways.

Exploring the Impact of Maladaptive Religious Schemata on Depression and Anxiety in a Muslim Student Sample

10:00–10:15 • Session 1: Culture, Identity & Culturally Responsive Wellbeing

Taregh Shaban, PhD1; Ian Grey, PhD2; Craig Steel, PhD3

- 1. School of Psychology, University of Birmingham Dubai
- 2. Department of Cognitive Sciences, United Arab Emirates University
- 3. University of Oxford

Abstract

Depression and anxiety are major concerns among university students in the GCC, where reported rates exceed global averages despite high levels of religiosity, which paradoxically, are often associated with better mental health. This study examined whether culturally shaped misinterpretations of religious teachings - conceptualised as maladaptive religious schemata (MRS) - are associated with elevated depression and anxiety scores among Muslim students.

To investigate whether childhood and adulthood MRS increase the likelihood of meeting clinical cut-offs for depression and anxiety, and whether particular religious subschemata show distinct relationships with student mental health.

A cross-sectional sample of 250 undergraduate students at a public university in the GCC completed the Child and Adult Religious Schema Questionnaires for Culturally Distorted Beliefs (C-ReSQue-CD and A-ReSQue-CD), the Patient Health Questionnaire-9, and the Generalised Anxiety Disorder-7. Logistic regression analyses examined associations between high ReSQue-CD scores and clinically significant symptoms while controlling for gender and religiosity.

Students with high C-ReSQue-CD or A-ReSQue-CD scores were approximately three times more likely to meet the clinical cut-off for depression. High childhood and adulthood ReSQue-CD scores also increased the likelihood of meeting the anxiety cut-off, with patterns varying by developmental stage.

The findings suggest that student mental health assessments should distinguish supportive religious beliefs from culturally distorted interpretations. Culturally sensitive, developmentally informed interventions may help clinicians and university wellbeing services address religiously framed guilt, fear, shame, and anxiety without undermining students' faith commitments.

Complex yet integrated: The well-being of Third Culture Kids (TCKs) in the multicultural context

10:15–10:30 • Session 1: Culture, Identity & Culturally Responsive Wellbeing

Magdalena Mosanya, PhD1

- 1. Murdoch University Dubai

Abstract

Background: Social changes of the twenty-first century increased the number of people who grow up "between cultures" in "mobile" families. This research project deals with the broadly understood well-being of multicultural individuals defined as third culture kids (TCKs) who spent a significant part of their developmental years in cultures different from their parents' cultures. The features that all TCKs have in common are international mobility (transience), permanent contact with cultural diversity, and the need to negotiate personal, social, and cultural identity in response to changing cultural contexts (cultural homelessness). Aims: The research project comprises three studies. Two studies aimed to analyse the relationships between the broadly understood well-being of TCKs in the UAE with multicultural identity configurations, including psychosocial mediators. The third study explored the sociocultural adaptation and acculturative stress of TCKs in relation to three groups of factors: individual, social, and cultural. Method: S1- mixed methods (N=122, females, 60% South Asian, age M= 20.3, SD=3), S2- quantitative, cross-sectional (N=399, 74% females, 64% South Asian, age M= 21.2, SD=2.9), S3 - quantitative, cross-sectional (N=322, 75% females, 71% South Asian, age M= 20.2, SD=3.1). Results: We showed that TCKs' well-being depends on internal integration versus identity compartmentalisation and categorisation, not mere exposure to diversity or international mobility. We confirmed the hypotheses about the enhancing role of global mindset, cultural intelligence, and social support. Conclusion: This project significantly deepened our understanding of how a TCK's identity interconnects with their overall well-being and social functioning, highlighting the vital resources (i.e. multicultural identity integration) that contribute to their thriving.

“Do You Understand My Culture?” Broaching Culture and Mental Wellbeing Among Emirati Youth

10:30–10:45 • Session 1: Culture, Identity & Culturally Responsive Wellbeing

Saeed Alhemeiri¹; Mustafa Aydogan, PhD¹

• 1. Zayed University

Abstract

Mental health care is strengthened when clients feel that their identities, values, and sociocultural contexts are recognized within the therapeutic relationship. Broaching refers to counselors' intentional efforts to acknowledge and explore how culture, identity, and sociopolitical context shape clients' experiences and concerns (Day-Vines et al., 2007). Recent broaching literature further emphasizes openness, cultural humility, and willingness to engage cultural differences rather than avoid them (Aydogan et al., 2026; Depauw et al., 2025). This is particularly relevant in the UAE, where Emirati youth may receive care from providers trained within diverse and often Western-influenced mental health frameworks.

This ongoing qualitative study explores Emirati youths' experiences of cultural broaching in therapy. Preliminary analysis of three semi-structured interviews suggests four emerging themes: (a) “Ask, Don't Assume,” reflecting preference for therapists who approach culture with curiosity; (b) “How You Ask Matters,” emphasizing timing, permission, and sensitivity when addressing cultural topics; (c) “Shared Culture Does Not Guarantee Feeling Understood,” indicating that cultural similarity alone does not ensure culturally responsive care; and (d) “Feeling Understood Opens the Door,” reflecting how cultural responsiveness may influence trust, disclosure, withholding, and continued engagement. Additional interviews and analysis are ongoing, and further findings will be presented at the conference.

By centering Emirati youth voices, the study highlights the importance of understanding wellbeing within ongoing cultural and social transitions. Findings may inform culturally responsive interventions, broaching skills, provider training, professional standards, licensing procedures, and mental health policy in the UAE.

Beyond the Western model: how Black British communities cope with mental distress, and what it teaches us about culturally responsive support for students

10:45–11:00 · Session 1: Culture, Identity & Culturally Responsive Wellbeing

Obajide Alademerin^{1,2}; Siân Lowri Griffiths³; Luke Brown^{1,3}

- 1. University of Birmingham
- 2. Reliable Routes Psychological Services Ltd
- 3. Institute for Mental Health, University of Birmingham

Abstract

Student mental health support in UK institutions is largely built on Western, statutory models of care that overlook the cultural and community frameworks through which many students understand and manage distress. This is especially consequential for Black students, who face disproportionate mental health inequalities yet remain underserved by conventional provision.

This study explored how Black British communities recognise, manage and cope with mental distress. Using a constructionist qualitative design, we conducted nine online focus groups with 36 adults (aged 23–68), community members, mental health professionals and third-sector practitioners, and analysed the data using reflexive thematic analysis.

Five interconnected coping responses emerged: mental resilience (emotional suppression as adaptive survival); faith in distress (church and prayer as primary support); and escapism through substances. Notably, two further themes were distinctly generational and novel: physical and creative release — exercise, music and poetry as therapeutic outlets and increasingly open peer support, with younger people, and young men in particular, moving from activity-based companionship toward direct emotional dialogue. These emerging, strengths-based practices signal a cultural shift among exactly the age group entering higher education.

I will draw out the implications for student mental health: how universities might embed culturally responsive support that builds on faith, creative expression and peer connection rather than replacing them, and how belonging and early intervention could be reimagined for Black and minoritised students. The talk argues for prevention co-developed with communities, not imported onto them.

Social Anxiety and Student Wellbeing: Understanding Pathways to Social Disconnection and Loneliness

11:00–11:15 • Session 2: Digital & Relational Wellbeing

Rabea Aftab¹

- 1. Bath Spa University RAK Campus, Ras Al Khaimah, UAE

Abstract

Social anxiety is a prevalent and often overlooked challenge among young adults and university students. Characterised by fears of negative evaluation and rejection, social anxiety can affect how young people engage with others, form relationships, and experience belonging, with wider consequences for student wellbeing, social connectedness, and loneliness. The present study aimed to explore how social anxiety may be associated with loneliness among university students, with particular attention to the interpersonal experiences that may contribute to this relationship. Data were collected from 400 university students in the UAE. Standardised measures were used to assess social anxiety, interpersonal problems, and loneliness. A mediation analysis using the PROCESS macro was conducted to examine whether interpersonal problems mediated the relationship between social anxiety and loneliness. The findings showed a significant relationship between social anxiety and loneliness, with interpersonal problems emerging as a significant mediator of this association. These findings highlight that the impact of social anxiety may extend beyond individual psychological distress to the quality of young people's social relationships and their experience of connectedness. The findings suggest that loneliness should not be addressed solely as an isolated wellbeing concern; understanding the interpersonal difficulties underlying social disconnection may be critical to effective prevention and intervention. For universities and student support services, this highlights the importance of moving beyond symptom-focused approaches towards interventions that strengthen social confidence, interpersonal functioning, meaningful social connection, and belonging. Addressing these relational pathways may provide a more holistic approach to redefining student mental health and wellbeing.

Shaping Selves in the digital age the Intercalate relationship between AI Overuse, Identity Formation, and Interpersonal Behaviour in University Students

11:15–11:30 · Session 2: Digital & Relational Wellbeing

Malak Elghayish¹; Razia Anjum, PhD¹

• 1. Bath Spa University RAK Campus, Ras Al Khaimah, UAE

Abstract

The rapid integration of artificial intelligence technologies into everyday life has transformed the way university students learn, communicate, and interact with others. While AI tools offer significant educational and practical benefits, concerns have emerged regarding the potential consequences of excessive reliance on these technologies. This study aims to elucidate the relationship between generative AI overuse, identity formation, and interpersonal behaviors among university students. Specifically to examine whether Generative AI overuse is associated with changes in students' identity formation and interpersonal interactions, and whether identity formation mediates the relationship between AI overuse and interpersonal behavior. Study utilized the quantitative methodology, surveying 300 (150 Male, 150 Female) university students was used and data was collected through convenient sampling technique. Representative sample consisted at 300 university students of diverse community including UAE Nationals, Egyptians, Pakistani, Indian, and Philippines community. Valid and reliable psychological instruments were used to explore the variable effects; Generative AI Dependency Scale (Goh et al., 2025) was used to explore the individual differences in dependency on generative AI systems, whereas, the Online Self Presentation Scale Adult Version (Wood et al., 2016) was used to evaluate that how people display themselves in digital space. These dimensions include adoptable self, authentic self and online freedom of self, and Scale for Interpersonal Behaviours (Arrindell et al., 2002) was used to explore the difficulty and distress in assertiveness. Correlation, regression, independent samples t-tests, one-way ANOVA, and moderation analyses were used to analyze the data. The findings indicate that generative AI overuse significantly associated with identity formation among university students, reflecting the growing influence of AI technologies on students' self-concept and personal development. Furthermore, the results reveal significant relationships among AI overuse, identity formation, and interpersonal behavior. Identity formation was found to play a mediating role in the relationship between AI overuse and interpersonal behavior, suggesting that excessive dependence on AI may influence students' social interactions through its impact on their developing identities. The study concludes that AI overuse has important implications for university students' psychological and social development. Understanding how AI influences identity formation and interpersonal behavior can help educators, institutions, and policymakers develop strategies to promote healthy AI usage. The findings contribute to the growing body of literature on AI dependency and highlight the need for awareness programs and interventions aimed at reducing the potential negative effects of excessive AI use while maximizing its educational benefits.

AI as Support or Stressor: Artificial Intelligence, Student Mental Health, and Higher Education

11:30–11:45 • Session 2: Digital & Relational Wellbeing

Saima Nomaan¹

- 1. University of Birmingham Dubai

Abstract

Artificial intelligence (AI) is becoming increasingly embedded in university students' learning, help-seeking, and everyday digital lives, creating new possibilities for supporting mental health while introducing new psychological risks. This presentation examines AI's dual role as both a support and a stressor for student mental health and well-being in higher education. Drawing on a systematic review of 40 studies published between January 2023 and August 2025, identified through Scopus, ERIC, APA PsycINFO, and PubMed, the presentation synthesises evidence across AI-enabled chatbots, generative AI, adaptive learning tools, wearables, emotion-recognition systems, and predictive analytics. The findings indicate that AI-supported interventions can reduce symptoms of anxiety and depression, strengthen self-efficacy and problem-solving, enhance perceived social support, and support engagement and emotional well-being. However, these benefits coexist with important risks. Intensive or poorly regulated AI use may contribute to technostress, digital fatigue, emotional dependence, privacy concerns, algorithmic bias, and reduced human connection. Outcomes are also shaped by AI literacy, self-regulation, patterns of use, cultural attitudes towards help-seeking, and institutional policies and safeguards. The presentation argues that AI should not be understood simply as beneficial or harmful to student well-being. Its psychological effects depend on how, why, and within what institutional conditions it is used. Universities therefore need human-centred approaches that position AI as a complement to, rather than a replacement for, human support, while embedding governance, digital well-being practices, inclusive design, and appropriate pathways to professional support. These findings offer practical implications for educators, counsellors, policymakers, and institutions navigating AI-enabled student support.

Measuring the Wrong Variable: What a Sedentary-Behaviour App Can and Cannot Tell Us About Student Wellbeing

11:45–12:00 • Session 2: Digital & Relational Wellbeing

Hamid Mukhtar, PhD1

- 1. University of Birmingham Dubai

Abstract

Digital wellbeing tools face a delivery problem, not an efficacy problem. Mental health applications show real efficacy in controlled trials, yet usage data across 93 popular apps found a median 15-day retention of 3.9%. Whether an intervention is ever received is largely determined by design: a layer psychology has ceded to engineering.

This presentation draws on Sedentaware, a mobile system that detects prolonged sedentary behaviour and delivers adaptive feedback calibrated to each user's progress, and on a published framework mapping persuasion strategies onto motivation, ability and trigger. I present the prototypes that failed before one succeeded, and the behavioural reason for each: passive tracking raised awareness without changing behaviour; scheduled reminders produced habituation and abandonment. Persuasive mechanisms are not interchangeable, and choosing between them is a psychological problem first.

I then argue that such systems measure the wrong construct for wellbeing purposes. Prospective evidence indicates that mentally passive sedentary behaviour elevates depression risk ($RR = 1.17$), whereas mentally active sedentary behaviour does not ($RR = 0.98$). Current sensing systems, including my own, cannot distinguish them, and so interrupt studying as readily as disengaged scrolling.

I close with a feasibility study I am developing: passive sedentary sensing combined with brief context prompts that serve as both measure and training label, in a student population. Such an instrument could reach students who never present to services. Its central obstacles are not technical: defining the construct, validating the inferences, and setting the limits of consented monitoring are questions for psychology.

From Helicopter Parenting to Attitude towards Psychological Help-Seeking: A Predictive Model Among Malaysian Undergraduates

14:00–14:15 • Session 3: Coping, Support & Participation in Student Life

Surabhi Roy¹; Kristy Chong, PhD²; Shue Ling Chong, PhD^{1,3}

- 1. University of Nottingham Malaysia
- 2. Monash University Malaysia
- 3. University of Nottingham Ningbo China

Abstract

First-year undergraduates living away from home are particularly vulnerable to mental distress, yet psychological service utilization remains low. As of 2020, over 50% of university students in Malaysia struggle with stress and depression, and over 70% have reported anxiety, with these statistics continuing to rise. Therefore, understanding help-seeking in this expanding and vulnerable population is increasingly urgent. Grounded in the Self-Determination Theory, this study developed and tested a predictive model examining the influence of familial and academic factors on attitude towards seeking psychological help. Structural equation modelling was used to analyze data collected from 101 first-year undergraduates at the University of Nottingham, Malaysia. Results indicated, among students living away from home, helicopter parenting positively predicted perceived parental support and negatively predicted academic achievement. Perceived parental support positively predicted academic achievement and competence satisfaction. Additionally, competence satisfaction predicted a positive attitude towards psychological help-seeking. These findings highlight competence satisfaction as a key pathway linking familial and academic factors to help-seeking, with implications for early intervention among at-risk university students in collectivist cultural contexts.

Navigating PCOS at University: Coping Strategies, Psychological Wellbeing, and Social Support Among Female Students

14:15–14:30 • Session 3: Coping, Support & Participation in Student Life

Grace D'Mello^{1,2}

- 1. Department of Psychology, Christ (Deemed to be University), Bengaluru, India
- 2. Manipal Academy of Higher Education, Dubai, UAE

Abstract

Polycystic Ovary Syndrome (PCOS) and Polycystic Ovarian Disease (PCOD) are complex hormonal conditions affecting multiple dimensions of physical, psychological, and emotional wellbeing. Managing these conditions alongside academic and social demands may present additional challenges for university students. This qualitative study explored the experiences and coping strategies of female students associated with Christ University, Bengaluru, who had been diagnosed with PCOS or PCOD.

Data were collected through in-depth interviews and a focus group discussion and analysed using thematic analysis. Six key themes were identified: (1) Initial Diagnosis and Experience, characterised by confusion, frustration, and emotional distress surrounding diagnosis; (2) Symptoms Experienced, highlighting physical, psychological, and emotional challenges associated with symptoms such as irregular menstruation, weight gain, and hormonal fluctuations; (3) Lifestyle and Medical Coping Strategies, including dietary changes, physical activity, and medical interventions; (4) Psychological and Emotional Coping Strategies, including mindfulness, counselling, and self-acceptance; (5) Impact of Social Factors, emphasising the role of family, friends, stigma, and social support; and (6) Advice for Newly Diagnosed Individuals, highlighting awareness, emotional resilience, and supportive communities.

The findings demonstrate that managing PCOS/PCOD extends beyond physical symptom management and involves significant psychological and social dimensions. The study underscores the importance of holistic, student-centred support integrating medical care, psychological wellbeing, awareness, and supportive peer networks. These findings have implications for how universities can create informed, inclusive environments that better support students managing chronic health conditions while promoting wellbeing, connection, and resilience.

Coaching as Connection: Enhancing Student Wellbeing, Belonging and Development Through Peer Coaching

14:45–15:00 • Session 3: Coping, Support & Participation in Student Life

Lucy Bolton, PhD1; Benita Maben1; Emma Smail1; Joann Griffith, PhD1; Ke Guek Nee, PhD1

- 1. Heriot-Watt University

Abstract

Higher education institutions are increasingly challenged to support student mental health and wellbeing in ways that extend beyond traditional counselling and crisis interventions. Social connection, belonging, and access to preventative sources of support have emerged as important contributors to positive student outcomes and psychological wellbeing.

This presentation explores a global peer coaching initiative developed at Heriot-Watt University in collaboration with academic staff, the University Wellbeing Service, and the HW Coaching Lab. The programme trained MSc Business Psychology with Coaching students to deliver structured, supervised coaching conversations to undergraduate students seeking support with academic confidence, goal setting, time management, wellbeing, and future planning.

Drawing on participant feedback and programme evaluation, findings suggest that peer coaching contributed to enhanced self-confidence, increased feelings of belonging, greater motivation, and stronger engagement with academic challenges. Student coaches simultaneously reported improvements in coaching capability, reflective practice, communication skills, and professional identity development. These outcomes support growing evidence that peer coaching can enhance wellbeing while simultaneously strengthening learning, self-efficacy, and community building within higher education.

The paper argues that peer coaching represents a scalable and preventative wellbeing intervention that complements existing student support services by creating psychologically safe spaces for reflection, connection, and growth. Practical recommendations for implementation, supervision, and institutional adoption will be presented. As universities seek innovative approaches to student mental health, peer coaching offers a promising model that redefines wellbeing support through empowerment, mutual learning, and community engagement.

Teacher Burnout in the UAE: Exploring Burnout, Wellbeing and Proactive Coping

15:00–15:15 • Session 4: Stress, Resources & Educational Resilience

Tanya McGuane^{1,2}

- 1. Heriot-Watt University Dubai
- 2. Caya World Clinic, Dubai

Abstract

Teacher burnout has emerged as a significant global occupational health concern, contributing to declining workforce wellbeing, reduced job satisfaction, and increasing teacher attrition. These concerns are relevant within high-performance educational systems such as the United Arab Emirates (UAE), where demands may negatively impact educator mental health and workforce sustainability. This study investigated psychological burnout and proactive coping among public-school teachers in the UAE, with focus on gender differences and the potential protective role of proactive coping in wellbeing. A quantitative cross-sectional design was employed using data collected from 171 public-school teachers across the UAE. Participants completed the Maslach Burnout Inventory (MBI) and the Proactive Coping Inventory (PCI). Statistical analysis revealed significantly elevated burnout levels across the sample, with male teachers reporting significantly higher burnout scores than female teachers ($p = .025$). This finding is noteworthy as it contrasts with common assumptions surrounding emotional strain within teaching professions and may reflect the psychosocial pressures experienced by male expatriate educators in demanding international educational environments. Occupational workload, cultural expectations, relocation-related stress, and provider-role pressures may contribute to increased vulnerability within this cohort. No statistically significant gender differences were identified in proactive coping strategies. The findings highlight the growing psychological burden experienced by educators within demanding educational environments and reinforce the importance of preventative wellbeing initiatives within educational systems. The study contributes region-specific insight into burnout in the Middle East and identifies the need for institutional approaches that support resilience, stress management, and educator wellbeing to promote sustainable human performance and workforce retention.

Supporting Students Under Strain: Staff Resources, Professional Identity and Wellbeing During Regional Conflict

15:30–15:45 • Session 4: Stress, Resources & Educational Resilience

Gary Pheiffer, PhD1

- 1. Heriot-Watt University Dubai

Abstract

Regional conflict places university staff in a dual position: managing uncertainty themselves while supporting students and maintaining educational continuity. Drawing on Conservation of Resources (COR) theory and an identity-motive perspective, this study examined how conflict affected staff resources, professional identity and capacity to support student wellbeing in UAE higher education.

Twenty-five teaching and research faculty and professional administrative staff participated in semi-structured interviews. Data were analysed using thematic analysis, informed by COR concepts of resource loss, resource caravans and resource caravan passageways, alongside identity motives including efficacy, meaning, belonging and continuity.

Some initial themes were: First, uncertainty depleted staff members' emotional and cognitive resources while increasing demands for reassurance, flexibility and guidance. Second, supporting students became identity-relevant: it protected professional meaning and efficacy but intensified strain when staff lacked information, authority or resources. Third, faculty and professional staff acted as resources for students by interpreting communications, adapting academic or administrative processes, providing emotional support and connecting students with assistance. Finally, institutional conditions shaped this resource transfer. Timely communication, role clarity, managerial support and flexibility created resource caravan passageways that enabled staff to assist students; ambiguity and workload pressure constrained their capacity.

The findings demonstrate that student wellbeing depends partly on the resources and wellbeing of those providing support. Universities should protect staff capacity through credible communication, manageable workloads, role clarity, managerial support and effective referral pathways. Sustaining staff resources strengthens institutional support for student mental health and wellbeing during conflict.

Redefining Campus Wellbeing in Southeast Asia: A Participatory Framework Addressing Socio-Economic Determinants and Institutional Stigma

1:00 – 1:06

Fathimma Maharin

- 3rd-year Undergraduate Student, Heriot-Watt University

Abstract

Mainstream higher education mental health strategies rely overwhelmingly on Western, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, and Democratic (WEIRD) paradigms of mental health, framing student distress as an individual psychological problem, reduced to seasonal examination anxiety and managed through individual clinical therapy. Student distress in Southeast Asia is chronic, relational, and deeply socio-economic, driven by financial vulnerability, intense familial expectations, low mental health literacy, and pervasive social stigma, all accelerated by severe institutional resource limits. This idea moves campus strategy from reactive, underutilized crisis clinical management to a low-stigma, culturally grounded support ecosystem that promotes everyday student flourishing.

Rather than treating distress as an isolated clinical symptom, this research suggests a sustainable, community-anchored care ecosystem that addresses root socio-economic and cultural determinants. It includes three essential elements: informal peer networks for low-stigma support, faculty gatekeeper training for early intervention in academic difficulties, and targeted parent psycho-education to change family expectations toward collaborative support.

The project is an exploratory, qualitative study with participatory co-design workshops and focus groups directly with students. Rather than top-down interventions, students are active co-creators and prototypers of low-resource support pathways responsive to their lived experience and institutional limits.

The project is at an advanced stage of concept and framework development with a structured roadmap for execution. Mid 2026: Institutional ethics approval and recruitment of participants. We plan to conduct qualitative co-design workshops and thematic data analysis in late 2026 with framework validation and final institutional reporting in early 2027.

More Than a Student

1:06 – 1:12

Maha Mohiuddin

- Murdoch University Dubai

Abstract

University is usually described as a time of self-discovery, personal growth, and preparation for the future. However, in an environment where grades, productivity, internships, and career plans are constantly emphasised, being a university student can sometimes become more than just one part of a person's identity. For some students, academic achievement becomes closely connected to self-worth: "If I am succeeding, I am doing well; but if I am struggling, then I am failing as a person."

This exploratory research idea examines academic identity over-identification, when a student's sense of self becomes heavily centred on university, academic performance, and future career success. The project asks: what happens when university becomes someone's entire identity?

For some students, there may also be a fear of being average. Being a high-achieving student can create pressure to constantly do more and stand out. The fear of receiving an average grade, having an ordinary career, or not becoming the "successful" person others expect can become closely tied to identity.

The project would explore whether students who strongly connect their self-worth to achievement experience setbacks and uncertainty more intensely. It would also consider the emotional cost of being a high-achieving student, including stress, perfectionism, anxiety, burnout, and guilt around not doing enough.

This project is currently at an early development stage. Future steps could include a literature review followed by a small-scale survey or interview study. The findings could help us better understand pressures often normalised in university culture and potentially inform wellbeing initiatives that encourage students to build a sense of identity beyond academic achievement.

From Stress to Stillness: Towards Scalable Non-Invasive Sound Therapy for Student Well-being

1:12 – 1:18

Ajitha Panneerselvam¹; Sasirekha Ayyalusamy² (Co-author); Kriti Ramalingam Muthamilselvan³ (Co-author)

- ¹Department of Applied Health Research, College of Medicine and Health, University of Birmingham Dubai, Dubai, UAE.
- ²Department of Naturopathy and Yogic Sciences, Sivaraj Naturopathy and Yoga Medical College, The Tamil Nadu Dr. M.G.R. Medical University, Chennai, Tamil Nadu, India. ³Department of Finance, College of Social Sciences, Birmingham Business School, University of Birmingham Dubai, Dubai, UAE.

Abstract

Background: Academic pressure traps university students in prolonged Beta brainwave states, maintaining high cortisol and preventing cellular recovery. A 2021 study showed that spending 15 seconds in N1 sleep-onset - shifting from Alpha to Theta waves - triples problem-solving capacity and reduces mental exhaustion, a method used historically by Edison and Einstein.

Relevance: Stress often drives students to maladaptive behaviors. In the UAE, 20.4% of university students smoke, with 43.4% identifying stress as the primary catalyst. Shifting to a 6 Hz Theta state activates the vagus nerve, initiating parasympathetic dominance. Randomized controlled trials show theta-band binaural beats significantly reduce student stress, anxiety, depression, fatigue, and tension, yielding large effect sizes (Cohen's $d = 0.81-1.33$).

Nature & Implementation: This exploratory, applied project proposes establishing simple, non-invasive, cost-effective sound therapy stations in quiet campus zones. Students will use headphones to listen to a 10-minute, 6 Hz Theta binaural beat protocol to lower acute stress, reduce cravings, and restore focus.

Timeline: The project is in the initial conceptual stage. Post-conference, student representatives plan to distribute anonymized questionnaires to track stress habits and evaluate intervention efficacy.

Xodo: Connecting Tools to Students

1:18 – 1:24

Ishani Poddar, Briti Lilaramani

• University of Birmingham Dubai

Abstract

There are many research-backed resources available to improve student mental health and well-being. But they all face the same problem: getting students actually to use them over a long period of time. They face high dropout and abandonment rates because students are just too busy to integrate another time-consuming chore into their daily lives. Specifically, mental wellbeing-related apps rarely give students any lasting sense that their effort is accumulating, making each use feel like starting over, which eventually leads to low engagement once the initial novelty wears off, leading students back to square one.

That is why we want to create Xodo, an ambient on-screen companion that quietly lives on your desktop, acting as a wellbeing tool that bridges the engagement gap by providing existing self-help resources and activities. Engagement isn't aimed at feeling like a chore, but rather as a fun break to just exist, and questions are intentionally reflective and offbeat rather than purely clinical, lowering the stakes to entry while still generating authentic content.

Xodo will be a community-powered tool where collective engagement builds a shared path without exposing individual struggles. Xodo is aimed at taking the pressure off wellbeing, making it fun and quirky. This idea is applied - once the app is created, we would want to roll it out like an app, inviting educational institutions to include it in their student help resources. Xodo is currently an idea we wish to explore further and conduct a pilot study with.

Beyond Individual Resilience: Applying Human Factors Psychology to Redesign University Environments for Student Wellbeing

1:24 – 1:30

Grace D'Mello

• Manipal Academy of Higher Education, Dubai, UAE

Abstract

Student mental health initiatives often focus on helping individuals cope with stress, anxiety, and academic pressure. While individual support remains important, less attention is given to how university systems and environments themselves may unintentionally contribute to psychological strain. Drawing on principles from human factors psychology, this exploratory research concept proposes examining how features of the academic environment—including clustered deadlines, unclear communication, excessive digital demands, cognitive overload, and competing academic responsibilities—may influence student wellbeing.

The proposed project aims to shift the focus from asking how students can become more resilient to asking how educational environments can be better designed around human cognitive and psychological needs. The concept is directly relevant to student mental health and wellbeing, particularly in relation to academic pressure, learning environments, digital wellbeing, and institutional support.

The project is currently at the exploratory stage. The proposed first phase would involve qualitative interviews or focus groups with university students to identify common sources of unnecessary cognitive and psychological strain. Findings would inform the development of a preliminary Human Factors Audit for Student Wellbeing, which could later be piloted within a university setting to identify opportunities for system-level improvements.

SANAD – Research Pitch

1:30 – 1:36

Nimisha Soni

- Emirates Development Bank – Future Founders Programme, Cohort 2026

Abstract

Sanad, meaning “pillar” or “support” in Arabic, is a student-focused peer wellbeing initiative designed to provide a low-stakes first step for university students experiencing stress, anxiety, or emotional difficulties. Students aged 17-22 in the UAE, particularly first-year and final-year students facing major academic and life transitions, are the initial target group. The concept addresses a gap between experiencing distress and seeking professional therapy, where students may hesitate because counselling can feel clinical, exposing, or culturally sensitive.

Sanad is an applied and exploratory concept that would initially be implemented as a small-scale campus pilot. Senior psychology students or recent psychology graduates would be recruited and trained as peer wellbeing mentors under the supervision of a licensed psychologist. Students could access a confidential conversation through WhatsApp Business, removing the need for a new application, formal booking process, or upfront cost. Mentors would not provide therapy; instead, concerns exceeding peer-support boundaries would follow a defined same-day escalation pathway to professional services.

The initiative is relevant to student mental health because untreated stress and anxiety can affect academic performance, engagement, relationships, and overall wellbeing. By creating an accessible bridge to appropriate support, Sanad aims to encourage earlier help-seeking and reduce the stigma surrounding mental health support.

Research status: Sanad is currently at the idea and early exploration stage. The next phase involves reviewing existing evidence, recruiting 4-5 founding mentors, developing the pilot framework, and conducting a two-week campus pilot. Feedback from students and wellbeing professionals will then be used to assess feasibility before any larger implementation or formal research study.

Experiences of Precrastination in the Creative Process of College Students

1:36 – 1:42

Jhian Bautista Samson

• Undergraduate Student, Bath Spa University, Ras Al Khaimah

Abstract

Background: The idea is based on the concept of Precrastination. Coined by David A. Rosenbaum (2014), Precrastination is defined by the tendency/willingness to accomplish a due task early despite requiring additional cognitive or physical work. To expand this described phenomenon, the concept examines the effect Precrastination has on the creative process within students' work and its aftereffects.

Relevance: Many students are aware of the harms procrastination has on motivation and the ability to complete tasks. However, it is crucial to understand the opposite spectrum – finishing tasks way too early is equally draining and affects the overall quality of their tasks, especially tasks that require creativity. Many students were always taught that the early bird catches the worm, but this never emphasises that sometimes the worm would not always be there at the earliest hour. Creativity in academic tasks requires experimentation, notice of the finer details, and constant review – all of which require time and spacing. This idea could not only help students but could also stimulate further research on the harms of Precrastination, as at the current moment not much psychological and empirical research is done on Precrastination.

Idea: The project is exploratory, seeking to understand the potential effects it has on student motivation, wellbeing, and their work process. The proposed method is an open-ended interview, analyzed using thematic analysis, with a sample of university students (preferably students majoring in creative fields or who partake in creative endeavours). Based on the thematic analysis, themes would be constructed from the data.

Timeline: The project is currently in the idea phase.

Returning to Fitrah: Redefining Muslim Student Wellbeing Beyond Western Models

1:42 – 1:48

Aabish Imran

• BSc Psychology, Year 2, University of Birmingham Dubai

Abstract

Do fitrah-related constructs predict psychological wellbeing in Muslim university students above and beyond established predictors such as academic self-efficacy and social support?

University mental health support is primarily built on Western psychological models. These models measure things like stress, life satisfaction, and social connection, and they work. But for Muslim students, there is a spiritual side of wellbeing that no one is measuring. Feeling aligned with one's purpose, living according to one's moral values, and trusting in God's plan are everyday psychological experiences that shape how Muslim students feel, cope, and function. However, these are absent from the tools universities currently use to understand and support student mental health. Redefining student mental health means expanding beyond Western paradigms to include how students from Islamic traditions understand their own flourishing. This is particularly relevant in the UAE, where universities have a large Muslim population.

This study investigates whether fitrah-related factors – specifically a sense of spiritual purpose, moral self-congruence, and trust in God (tawakkul) – predict psychological wellbeing in Muslim university students, even after accounting for established predictors like academic self-efficacy and social support. Fitrah, in Islamic psychology, refers to the innate human disposition toward goodness and connection to God (Qur'an, 30:30), and has been positioned by scholars from Al-Ghazali to Rothman (2021) as foundational to human flourishing.

The proposed method is a research-based cross-sectional survey of 150–200 Muslim university students in the UAE. Participants would complete the Warwick-Edinburgh Mental Wellbeing Scale (WEMWBS) alongside a fitrah-aligned measure adapted from Rothman's Islamic Psychology framework. Hierarchical regression would test whether fitrah constructs explain additional variance in wellbeing beyond standard predictors.

The study is expected to take approximately 8–9 months: literature review and measure development (months 1–3), ethics approval (month 4), data collection (months 5–6), data analysis (months 7–8), and write-up (month 9).

Promoting Emotional Well-being in Schools: Practical Strategies for Supporting Children's Mental Health

12:00-14:00

Ms. Shahina Usman

• GEMS Cambridge International Private School, Sharjah

Abstract

The transition from school to higher education represents a significant developmental shift, during which students face changes in academic demands, independence, and emotional responsibility. This study explores pre-university students' perceptions of mental health and their expectations of academic and emotional adjustment in higher education.

Although awareness of mental health has increased among adolescents, variability remains in how students understand wellbeing, coping, and resilience. This study aims to examine how students conceptualise mental health and how these perceptions influence their expectations of university life, particularly regarding stress management, independence, and social adaptation.

A qualitative exploratory approach will be used. Data will be collected through semi-structured group discussions and reflective prompts with students in their final year of secondary education preparing for higher studies. Participants will share their understanding of mental health, anticipated challenges in university transition, and perceived coping strategies. The data will be analysed using thematic analysis to identify key patterns in perceptions, expectations, and gaps between anticipated and likely lived experiences.

Preliminary observations suggest that students demonstrate general awareness of mental health concepts but may lack practical readiness for applying coping strategies during transition. The study highlights the importance of structured pre-university mental health preparation, focusing on emotional literacy, realistic expectation-building, and adaptive coping skills.

Findings aim to inform school-based counselling practices and transition support programmes that enhance psychological readiness for higher education and promote smoother adjustment during this critical developmental stage.

'Escaping Through Fantasy' - Maladaptive Daydreaming as A Bridge Between Perceived Loneliness and Psychological Distress

12:00-14:00

Mahik Sohail

• University of Greater Manchester (UGMRAK)

Abstract

Maladaptive daydreaming, the act of vivid absorption in daydreaming over long periods of time, was an under-researched mechanism prevalent in young adults. The human experience of perceived loneliness was highlighted as a predictor of MD that led to heightened levels of psychological distress due to investment in daydreaming activities. The study aimed to establish predictors of psychological distress in young adults and explore maladaptive daydreaming as a mediator between perceived loneliness (predictor) and psychological distress (outcome). A total of 104 participants, aged 18-30 years old, were recruited via volunteer sampling through social media and online forums. Online surveys included the UCLA Loneliness scale (Version 3), the 16-item Maladaptive Daydreaming Scale (MDS-16), and the Kessler Psychological Distress scale, which were utilised to measure loneliness, maladaptive daydreaming, and psychological distress. Results revealed that loneliness and maladaptive daydreaming significantly predicted psychological distress. Maladaptive daydreaming also partially mediated the relationship between loneliness and psychological distress. A few limitations of the study were discussed. Future studies would benefit from addressing the gap in a longitudinal research design within diverse age groups. Theoretical and clinical implications included the application of such findings in the development of screening measures for maladaptive daydreaming, and aiding clinicians in the development of interventions to combat maladaptive daydreaming and reduce psychological distress in young adults.

Keywords: Maladaptive Daydreaming, Perceived Loneliness, Psychological Distress, Young adults, Mediation model.

From Discomfort to Acceptance

12:00-14:00

Natalie Tayim

- Middle East Psychological Association

Abstract

Within the conservative sociocultural framework of Qatar, discussions around sexuality education are often viewed as taboo, leading to a significant disconnect between young people's reproductive health requirements and the scant information they receive. This research investigates the profound effects of a graduate-level sexuality course offered at a graduate university in Doha, Qatar. Employing a mixed-methods methodology that includes sentiment analysis and thematic analysis, the study examines reflective essays from nine students. Prominent themes identified include an emotional journey transitioning from discomfort to acceptance, the therapeutic benefits of reflective writing, the destigmatization of anatomical knowledge and pleasure, the importance of safe and inclusive educational environments, and the varying experiences of gender in sexual conversations. Despite a backdrop of initial resistance influenced by cultural and religious beliefs, participants noted advancements in self-awareness, emotional intelligence, and critical thought regarding relationships, gender roles, and sexual identity. The positive sentiment scores, in conjunction with qualitative insights, suggest that comprehensive sexuality education can serve as a catalyst for personal transformation. The study emphasizes that educational contexts that are culturally responsive and sensitive from a contextual perspective could even in conservative societies enable a meaningful engagement with sexuality education.

To Persist, or Not To Persist?: The Piloting and Validation of a Novel Questionnaire That Measures Multidimensional Student Stress

12:00-14:00

Amaan Iqbal Ibrahim

• University of Birmingham Dubai

Abstract

Student mental health has emerged as one of the most significant challenges facing higher education. While numerous instruments assess stress, anxiety and wellbeing, many focus predominantly on academic pressures or general psychological distress, providing only a partial understanding of the complex factors that influence students' ability to thrive and persist in higher education. This study introduces the 3-S Framework, a novel multidimensional model developed to conceptualise and measure student stress across three interconnected domains: Self-Perception, Perceived Role in Society, and Spending & Financial Literacy.

The framework proposes that student stress extends beyond academic demands and is shaped by the interaction between students' internal beliefs about themselves, their perceived social value and expectations, and their confidence in managing financial challenges. Drawing upon established psychological, sociological and behavioural economic theories, the framework informed the development of the 3-S Questionnaire, a new psychometric instrument designed to assess these three dimensions comprehensively.

The presentation will outline the theoretical rationale underpinning the framework, describe the systematic process used to generate questionnaire items, and present the planned methodology for piloting and psychometric validation, including item analysis, reliability testing, exploratory factor analysis and construct validation. The potential applications of the framework within universities will also be discussed, particularly its role in early identification of at-risk students, informing targeted wellbeing interventions, and supporting evidence-based student retention strategies.

By moving beyond traditional conceptualisations of student stress, the 3-S Framework offers a holistic perspective that may enhance both research and institutional practice, while contributing towards more personalised approaches to promoting student mental health and persistence in higher education.

NoAIphobia: The Psychological Double Bind of Student AI Use in Higher Education

12:00-14:00

Mohammad Aarif

- Student, Rochester Institute of Technology, Dubai (Department of Electrical Engineering and Computing Sciences), United Arab Emirates

Abstract

Generative AI has become part of daily academic life, but a wave of 2026 research reveals its psychological costs are more complex than a simple “helpful or harmful” debate. This talk explores what researchers are now calling “noAIphobia” — a documented anxiety students feel at the thought of working without AI — and its mirror image, AI-use stigma: the fear of being judged as lazy or dishonest for using it. Together, these form a genuine psychological double bind, one that intensifies among the most academically conscientious students. This dilemma is reinforced by two further strands of evidence: EEG research linking heavy AI reliance to weaker neural connectivity, poorer recall, and a diminished sense of ownership over one's own writing; and survey findings describing a “self-efficacy paradox,” in which AI use boosts students' immediate confidence while deepening long-term dependence. Drawing on emerging Gulf-region evidence, including a 2026 UAE study linking AI-help-seeking behaviour to anxiety, stress and depression, the presentation considers how these dynamics play out both globally and locally. It closes with practical implications for institutions: moving from punitive detection toward AI-literacy frameworks and open disclosure that protect students' confidence, authentic learning, and psychological safety. Findings will interest educators, mental health practitioners, and policymakers shaping human-centred AI policy in higher education.

How Can Redefining Social Media Better Support Student Wellbeing?

12:00-14:00

Samreen Saleem

- Student, RIT Dubai

Abstract

Social media plays a significant role in student life, providing opportunities for communication, connection, and access to information, while also presenting potential challenges to mental health. This study builds upon previous research examining the impact of social media on student mental health, particularly students' reliance on social media for communication and social connection alongside negative effects on mental health and self-esteem.

While previous research has explored these effects, less attention has been given to whether social media engagement itself can be restructured to preserve its beneficial functions while reducing potentially harmful patterns of use. This study addresses this gap by exploring a hypothetical alternative model of social media that prioritises communication, connection, and useful content while reducing features associated with prolonged engagement.

The study will examine findings from the initial survey and use them to inform the proposed model. A new sample will then be presented with the model and complete a follow-up survey containing comparable questions, alongside additional questions assessing perceptions of the model and willingness to engage with it.

By comparing responses across the two surveys, the study aims to examine whether an alternative approach to social media engagement could address students' concerns while preserving the communication and connection they value. The findings may provide insight into more balanced approaches to social media use and contribute to discussions surrounding student mental health, digital wellbeing, and healthier online environments for students.

The Gut–Brain Axis and Student Stress: A Literature-Based Proposal for a University Wellness Intervention Programme

12:00-14:00

Bayan Khalid, Reem Albinkhalil

• British University of Bahrain; University of Salford — Department of Psychology

Abstract

Aim: This study aims to investigate the relationship between gut health behaviours and perceived stress levels among university students while designing a focused well-being intervention programme to enhance student mental health.

Approach: To address this aim, the study will primarily be based on a structured literature review methodology to assess how researchers are currently examining the relationship between the gut-brain axis and stress/anxiety in young adults. Peer-reviewed studies from psychology, neuroscience, and nutrition literature will be analysed to identify mechanisms linking gut microbiota with emotional regulation and stress responses. Additionally, the proposed study will also conduct an exploratory survey of university students to collect self-reported data on stress levels and lifestyle factors associated with gut health (i.e., dietary habits, caffeine use, sleep patterns, and gastrointestinal symptoms). Perceived stress will be assessed using a standardised measure such as the Perceived Stress Scale (PSS), alongside a brief dietary assessment adapted from a Food Frequency Questionnaire (FFQ). This portion of the study will only be conducted after receiving the necessary ethical approvals for human-subjects research. Should those approvals not be received by the end of this project's timeline, the study will proceed with the results of the literature review.

Relevance: Emerging studies on the gut-brain axis have linked intestinal functions in the gastrointestinal system with psychological processes in the brain; associating gut microbiota with stress physiology, inflammation, and emotional regulation (Clapp et al., 2017; Appleton, 2018). Meanwhile, both stress driven by academic pressure, competition, and social demands, and lifestyle factors such as high levels of caffeine, irregular sleep, and diet are common among university students, impacting their overall psychological well-being (Claydon et al., 2023; Pérez-Jorge et al., 2025). Despite this, awareness of the gut-brain axis and its influence on stress levels remains limited in the student population, with diet and nutrition overlooked as potential factors in stress management.

Impact: Based on findings from the literature, this paper proposes a student-focused wellness intervention that combines psychoeducation on the gut–brain axis, gut-supportive lifestyle guidance, and stress-regulation techniques aimed at improving student well-being. The proposed framework highlights the potential value of interdisciplinary approaches integrating psychology, neuroscience, and nutrition in addressing student stress and promoting holistic well-being.

Exploring Intention Offloading and Digital Reminder Usage Among College Students: Cross-Cultural Qualitative Study

12:00-14:00

Kavikkuil G J¹, T. Lavanya², Taramol K G³

- ¹PhD Scholar, Department of Psychology, University of Madras, Chennai, Tamil Nadu; ²Professor & Head, Department of Psychology, University of Madras, Chennai, Tamil Nadu; ³Associate Professor, Department of Economics, Symbiosis International University, Dubai

Abstract

As technology becomes increasingly ubiquitous, smartphones and other digital devices have become integral to daily life. Traditional reminder methods such as notes and diaries, have evolved into digital reminders for intended actions ranging from drinking water to completing tasks. Though the offloading helps to improve the performance of an individual, on the other side long term reliance on this increases concern in the internal memory processes. Since cognition and emotion are closely interconnected, understanding their relationship is essential for individual well-being. Despite increasing reliance on digital reminders, little is known about how emerging adults experience intention offloading in everyday life, particularly across culture. Therefore, this research aims to explore the intention-offloading behavior and reminder usage among college students using a cross-cultural qualitative research design. Data will be collected from college students between 18-25 years of age with access to smartphones from Chennai and in Dubai. India and Dubai provide contrasting sociocultural and technological environments while sharing high levels of smartphone use among young adults. Comparing these populations allows examination of whether intention offloading is influenced by cultural values and digital environments beyond individual cognitive differences. Purposive Sampling will be employed and the sample size will be determined on the basis of content saturation. Data will be collected using the semi-structured interview schedule, developed based on the Phase Model of Prospective Memory. Thematic analysis will be used to identify shared and context-specific themes. This study is expected to contribute to the understanding of the cultural influences on digital reminder usage and explore digital well-being. The findings may inform culturally sensitive interventions, digital well-being initiatives and future research on intention offloading and prospective memory among emerging adults.

Algorithmic Anxiety: AI Detection Systems and Student Distress in Higher Education

12:00-14:00

Mahnoor Raza

• University of Greater Manchester

Abstract

The rapid proliferation of generative artificial intelligence (AI) following ChatGPT's release in late 2022 prompted higher education institutions worldwide to adopt automated AI-detection systems (e.g., Turnitin, GPTZero) as frontline guardians of academic integrity. Early warnings that such detectors were not foolproof were largely unheeded as adoption accelerated. However, a growing body of 2022–2025 research reveals that these tools are technically unreliable, easily circumvented through paraphrasing, and systematically biased against non-native English writers, who are flagged as AI-generated at far higher rates than native speakers. This paper examines “algorithmic anxiety”: the psychological distress that emerges when opaque, probabilistic systems are granted authority over students' academic standing. Empirical and journalistic evidence documents specific manifestations including a persistent fear of false accusation, hypervigilance and self-censorship of authentic writing, avoidance of legitimate AI-assisted editing, time-consuming self-defense strategies, and diminished trust in instructors and institutions. This disproportionately affects multilingual and first-generation learners. The emotional toll (paranoia, self-doubt, and identity disruption) compromises both wellbeing and the learning experience. Drawing on detector-evaluation and student-perception studies, this paper offers evidence-based recommendations for institutions to restore trust: (1) abandon sole-evidence reliance on detection scores in misconduct proceedings; (2) redesign assessment toward process-oriented, authenticated, and oral formats; (3) develop transparent AI-use policies and critical AI literacy for staff and students; and (4) shift from a punitive policing paradigm toward a trust-based, dialogue-centred approach to integrity.

The Cost of Academic Excellence: The Relationship Between Maladaptive Perfectionism and Academic Burnout in High-Achieving University Students

12:00-14:00

Amena Kazzaz, Ebtisam Abounajmi, Farah Zghidi, Fatemehsadat Yousefi, Samar Amro, Mohammad Nami

- Cognitive Neuroscience and Neuropsychology Unit, School of Health Sciences and Psychology, Canadian University Dubai, Dubai, United Arab Emirates

Abstract

High-achieving university students often get compliments for their academic excellence, yet their perfectionistic traits may place them at a greater risk of stress and burnout. This study investigated the relationship between maladaptive perfectionism and academic burnout while looking into academic stress as a mediating factor in high-achieving undergraduate students. While previous studies have explored this topic, the existing literature remains limited, as it does not tap into the neurophysiological markers, which is a gap that this study addresses. A total of 51 high-achieving undergraduate students (37 females, 14 males) at Canadian University Dubai completed phase one, which included the Multidimensional Perfectionism Scale (MPS), Maslach Burnout Inventory-Student Survey (BMI-SS), and the Perception of Academic Stress Scale (PASS). 30 of the participants who scored high in the maladaptive perfectionism were included in phase two to do qEEG analysis (eyes open and eyes closed). However, only 19 participants completed the qEEG. Moreover, SPSS Pearson correlation results showed no correlation between maladaptive perfectionism and academic burnout. However, it revealed that academic stress fully mediates this relationship. Also, the qEEG analysis showed abnormalities in the F7 and F8 areas, which are the common hotspots for the Central Executive Network and Salience Network. These findings highlighted the role of academic stress in maladaptive perfectionist students and how it can lead to academic burnout. In addition, neurophysiological evidence shows that their brain activities are distinct from others. This study will contribute to the educational and neuropsychology field by shedding light on the dark side of academic excellence.

Evaluating the Impact of Error-Recognition Stress on Students' Selective Attention; a Neurocognitive, and RDoC-HiToP Informed Approach

12:00-14:00

Samar Amro

Abstract

Background and objectives: Error-recognition stress is defined as a type of stress that results from recognizing one's mistakes. This study aimed to investigate how error-recognition stress impacts undergraduate students' selective attention and identify the neurocognitive markers based on cognitive tests and Quantitative Electroencephalography (qEEG) measures. The paucity of research on the impact of error-recognition stress on cognitive outcomes in academic settings prompted the present investigation.

Methods: A quantitative within-subject study design included 48 undergraduate university students in Dubai, UAE. A total of 17 males and 31 females were included and underwent the State-Trait Anxiety Inventory and the RehaCom selective attention screening test before and after the Go/No-Go task, which was employed to induce error-recognition stress. In addition, qEEG markers were examined in a randomly-selected subset of participants.

Results: Findings revealed no significant change in the state anxiety or reaction-control measures post Go/No-Go task. However, reaction time was significantly improved after the Go/No-Go task ($p = 0.021$), mostly in participants who had fewer errors. The time-locked qEEG analysis showed a decreased Z-score in Alpha absolute power over bihemispheric occipital regions and theta synchronization in the frontocentral and left temporal areas in 7 random participants during the selective attention assessment.

Conclusion: The present findings suggest that mild error-recognition stress could lead to hypervigilance rather than hindering attention. This brings in new insights into exploring how various stressors impact cognitive functions. The present study proposes the impact of eustress among students and how it can contribute to their performance.

Productivity Guilt as a Manifestation of Maladaptive Perfectionism

12:00-14:00

Archita Kochhar

• University of Birmingham

Abstract

The issue of student mental health continues to be relevant at the university level, with cases of anxiety and academic burnout becoming increasingly common. Whereas there have been numerous studies examining the role of maladaptive perfectionism in the development of negative psychological conditions, the phenomenon of productivity guilt, or feelings of guilt and stress when not being engaged in academic productive activities, remains relatively unstudied. As a modern variant of maladaptive perfectionism, the purpose of this work-in-progress study is to explore the associations between productivity guilt, anxiety symptoms, and academic burnout in university students.

In order to collect data, a cross-sectional quantitative design will be used with approximately 50-100 university students recruited by means of online convenience sampling via social media. The participants will fill out an online questionnaire consisting of a productivity guilt measure adapted from literature on maladaptive perfectionism and self-criticism and the Generalized Anxiety Disorder-7 and the Maslach Burnout Inventory Student Survey. Such statistical methods as descriptive statistics, reliability analysis, Pearson's correlation, and multiple regression will be applied.

Based on previous literature, it is assumed that the higher the levels of productivity guilt, the more pronounced anxiety symptoms and academic burnout become.

Supporting Student Mental Health by Understanding Faculty Stress in Premedical Education

12:00-14:00

Uma Pandalai

Abstract

Background: Student mental health and wellbeing have become central priorities in higher education, particularly among premedical students who face intense academic competition and pressure. While considerable attention has been devoted to understanding student stress, comparatively little is known about the psychological burden experienced by faculty who teach and mentor these students. Faculty frequently serve as educators, advisors, mentors, and providers of emotional support while simultaneously managing increasing requests for grade reconsideration, recommendation letters, academic accommodations, and career guidance. Understanding faculty wellbeing is essential because educator wellbeing directly influences teaching quality, mentoring effectiveness, and the overall student learning environment.

Aim: This study aims to explore how interactions with premedical students influence faculty stress, identify the primary sources of psychological pressure, and examine the implications of faculty wellbeing for student mental health and institutional support systems.

Methods: A mixed-methods study was designed involving faculty members from biology, chemistry, physics, and psychology departments across diverse undergraduate institutions. Quantitative surveys assess perceived stress, workload, emotional demands, and institutional support, while qualitative interviews provide deeper insights into faculty experiences. Statistical analyses include descriptive statistics and comparisons across disciplines, complemented by thematic analysis of interview data.

Results: Preliminary findings indicate that faculty teaching large proportions of premedical students experience increased emotional labour associated with frequent grade negotiations, recommendation letter requests, repeated academic advising, and heightened student anxiety. Participants report that these responsibilities extend beyond traditional teaching roles and contribute to increased workload, emotional exhaustion, and reduced mentoring capacity. Faculty also describe limited institutional recognition of these demands and identify a need for structured support, workload adjustments, and professional development focused on managing challenging student interactions.

Conclusion: Supporting student mental health requires simultaneous investment in faculty wellbeing. Institutions seeking to foster psychologically healthy learning environments should recognise faculty emotional labour, implement policies that reduce unnecessary administrative burdens, and provide resources that strengthen mentoring and resilience among educators. By positioning faculty wellbeing as a critical component of student success, this study broadens the conversation surrounding mental health in higher education and offers practical recommendations for creating more sustainable educational environments.

Redefining Classroom Expectations: Creating Neuro Inclusive Learning Environments for Student Wellbeing

12:00-14:00

Nikita Sangtani

• Heriot-Watt University

Abstract

Traditional classrooms expect students to remain still, speak when spoken to, maintain attention, and follow standardized approaches to learning. However, these expectations may not accommodate the diverse ways in how students with autism communicate, regulate emotions and engage with their environment. This poster explores the importance of adopting neuroinclusive classroom practices that prioritise student wellbeing, accessibility, and inclusion. Drawing on insights from the International Autism Conference and current perspectives in neurodiversity, this work will highlight how approaches such as allowing movement, providing sensory accommodations, and offering flexible participation methods can support autistic students' emotional regulation and confidence.

By shifting from a compliance-based classroom to an interactive and acceptance based one, educational settings can create environments that allow neurodivergent students feel more understood and empowered. This poster aims to promote awareness of practical strategies educators can implement to foster belonging and improve wellbeing for learners with autism.

Borrowed Confidence: The AI Relief-Reliance Loop in Student Mental Health and Academic Self-Efficacy

12:00-14:00

Zenab Shahid

Abstract

Generative AI is now part of everyday university study, especially when students are under pressure, unsure how to begin, or struggling to manage demanding workloads. It can be genuinely useful. Students may use it to clarify difficult ideas, organise an argument, or receive feedback. However, the same tool may become problematic when it begins to replace the thinking that learning requires.

This poster uses a focused narrative review to explore how generative AI use may interact with academic stress, cognitive offloading and student wellbeing. It introduces the idea of “borrowed confidence”, meaning the feeling of competence that can come from producing polished work with AI even when the student’s own understanding has not developed to the same level.

The poster also proposes an AI Relief-Reliance Loop. Academic pressure may lead students to hand difficult thinking over to AI. The immediate sense of relief can make repeated use more likely, while fewer opportunities for independent problem solving may gradually weaken confidence in working alone. However, AI may also support learning when students attempt the task first, question the output and rebuild the reasoning themselves.

The review will consider the strengths and limitations of the current evidence, particularly its reliance on cross-sectional and self-report studies. It will conclude with the TRACE framework, a practical approach to using AI without giving up intellectual independence, academic confidence, or wellbeing.

Self-Esteem and Wellbeing Among Adolescents

12:00-14:00

Dr. Sreelekha N.

• Sharjah Indian School, Juwaiza

Abstract

Adolescence represents a crucial phase of human growth marked by substantial psychological, social and emotional transformation. Young individuals start to form their identities and become more independent during this time. Increased stress and emotional challenges can also be caused by peer pressure, parental expectations, academic responsibilities, and worries about board exams. Adolescents' self-esteem and general psychological health may be impacted by these experiences.

The current study looked at differences in wellbeing and self-esteem among 15–17-year-old higher secondary school students. 250 adolescents participated in the online study. Purposive sampling was used to choose the participants. The Diathesis-Stress Model, Selye's General Adaptation Syndrome, and the Transactional Model of Stress and Coping provided conceptual underpinning for the study. These viewpoints made it easier to comprehend how stressful events, personal vulnerabilities, and adolescents' stress reactions are related. Participants were examined using the Rosenberg Self-Esteem Scale, Perceived Stress Scale (PSS-10), Psychological Well-Being Scale, and Child and Adolescent Social Support Scale to assess self-esteem, perceived stress, psychological well-being, and social support.

The findings indicated that a majority of the participants reported low to moderate levels of self-esteem, which was associated with lower levels of overall well-being. Peer pressure, academic pressures, and board exam anxiety have all been cited as potential obstacles that teenagers may face during this developmental time. The study also highlighted the important role of family and teacher support in promoting healthy self-esteem and positive well-being.

Based on the findings, the study recommended the necessity for supportive interventions for adolescents experiencing low self-esteem. Strengthening family support, building strong teacher–student interactions, providing appropriate counselling services, and helping students develop effective coping techniques may contribute to increased psychological well-being. The findings underline the necessity of providing supportive school and family environments that address not only adolescents' academic demands but also their emotional and psychological development.

The data were analysed using the Statistical Package for the Social Sciences (SPSS). The study gives important insights into the factors impacting self-esteem and well-being among adolescents and underscores the need for preventive and supportive methods within educational contexts.

Pause and Reflect: A Randomized Study of Self-Affirmation and Mastery Recall

12:00-14:00

Fahimah Saiyed, Lucy Tawidian

• American University of Sharjah

Abstract

Background: In the UAE and wider Gulf region, stress is reported as one of the most common psychological concerns among students, while cultural norms may discourage help-seeking, emphasizing the need for practical and accessible stress-reduction approaches.

Methods: In a randomized between-subjects experimental design, we examine the efficacy of two self-based interventions, value affirmation—reflecting on values central to the self—and mastery recall affirmation—reflecting upon a time when a difficult life situation was successfully managed—relative to a control condition in buffering negative effects of an induced academic stressor among first- and second-year undergraduate students at the American University of Sharjah. Our main outcome was participants' self-reported stress experienced in the moment.

Results: In a pilot sample of 77 students (M age = 19.06, SD = 1.06) stress levels were not significantly different across conditions ($F(2, 74) = 1.05$, $p = 0.35$). However, both self-esteem and domain engagement, the extent to which students perceive academic success personally important, emerged as significant moderators, such that high self-esteem ($p < .001$) and low domain identification ($p = 0.006$) predicted lower levels of stress.

Conclusion: This suggests that while the interventions did not significantly reduce stress, in line with expectations, individual differences played an important role in students' stress responses. Results are then discussed in terms of refinements for the main phase of the study following insights from the effectiveness of the intervention manipulation.

Imposter Syndrome among Undergraduates: Examining the Roles of Field of Study and Gender

12:00-14:00

Ishan Misra, Ayesha Sarwar (Co-Author)

• Department of Psychology, Middlesex University Dubai

Abstract

Objective: Imposter syndrome (IS) is an internal experience wherein individuals consistently undermine their own abilities and deem themselves as fraudulent, despite apparent evidence of their accomplishments. Undergraduate students have shown vulnerability to IS, with women consistently reporting higher IS levels than men due to various reasons. However, prior research studies are limited in their generalizability due to excessive focus on STEMM undergraduates, with a dearth of research on IS in students of other fields. This study examined whether a student's field of study, their gender, and the interaction significantly predicted IS levels among undergraduate students in the United Arab Emirates.

Methods: A between-subjects factorial design was utilized, with students residing in and pursuing an undergraduate degree in the UAE being recruited via convenience and snowball sampling. A survey link containing the relevant questionnaires along with consent and debriefing information was shared, and a total of 161 participants' data was analyzed.

Results: Findings indicated that IS characteristics were prevalent in the sample, with a high number of students experiencing frequent IS feelings. The analysis provided inconclusive differences in IS between students of different fields and the interaction between field of study and gender. Conversely, gender significantly influenced IS levels, with female students reporting higher IS than males.

Conclusions: These findings highlight the widespread prevalence of IS among undergraduate students, even across disciplines. They also suggest the increased importance of gender in shaping IS experience among UAE undergraduates. Limitations, strengths, and directions for future studies were discussed to provide a foundational structure.

Does the Medium Matter? University Students' Preferences for Text- and Voice-Based Conversational AI in Digital Mental Health Support

12:00-14:00

Parvathii Renjith

Abstract

Conversational artificial intelligence (AI) is increasingly explored as digital mental health support, potentially addressing economic, systemic, and cultural barriers of traditional services. As AI-based support grows among young people, understanding how students experience different interaction modalities is essential. Existing research has examined text- and voice-based conversational AI separately, with comparative research largely quantitative and Western. This highlights a gap in student experiences within culturally diverse settings such as the UAE, where rapid AI adoption intersects with mental health needs.

This qualitative study explored university students' perception and preferences for text- versus voice-based conversational AI for digital mental health support, in collaboration with Mentra, a UAE-based AI mental health chatbot. Eleven University of Birmingham Dubai students observed standardised fictional interactions between an individual experiencing Generalized Anxiety Disorder and an AI chatbot in text and voice formats. Semi-structured interviews were analysed using Braun and Clarke's (2019) Reflexive Thematic Analysis.

Three themes emerged: Overall Experiences and Impressions of AI Chatbot Interaction; Contextual Factors Shaping Format Selection; and Format-Specific Attributes Influencing Preference. Participants valued AI's accessibility, convenience, and non-judgemental support, but perceived limited depth and human connection, viewing it as a complement rather than replacement for human support. Text was preferred for privacy, reflection, and task-focused support, though interactions could feel rigid. Voice was more emotionally engaging and convenient for multitasking, but raised privacy concerns. Preferences were dynamic, shaped by individual, situational, and modality features, highlighting the need for accessible, flexible, culturally responsive, and safe AI support aligned with diverse student needs.

Hyper Independence as a Barrier to Seeking Psychological Help Among Working Female University Students

12:00-14:00

Nishwa Tistic

Abstract

Hyper independence, the tendency to avoid relying on others even when support is genuinely needed, has been suggested as a psychological barrier to help-seeking, but there's still limited research testing this directly, especially among working women juggling both academic and job responsibilities. This study looked at the relationship between hyper independence and self-stigma around seeking psychological help in working female university students. Participants completed the Hyper Independence Questionnaire (HIQ) and the Self-Stigma of Seeking Help Scale (SSOSH). The results showed a significant positive correlation between hyper independence and self-stigma, $r = .503$, $p < .001$, with hyper independence explaining about 25.3% of the variance in self-stigma ($R^2 = .253$). In other words, students who scored higher on hyper independence also tended to report more discomfort around the idea of seeking psychological support, even though nothing suggests they were dealing with less distress than their peers.

These findings matter for student mental health and wellbeing because they suggest reluctance to seek help isn't always about access or awareness. Sometimes it comes down to how deeply someone has internalized the idea that needing support means weakness, especially for students balancing financial independence, academic pressure, and social expectations all at once. This points to a real need for university counseling services to treat self-reliance itself as a barrier worth addressing, not just the practical obstacles that stand between students and support.

Evaluating the Effectiveness of Virtual Reality Systematic Desensitization for Public Speaking Anxiety

12:00-14:00

Dr. Rupa Kalahasthi, Alisar Kaysoun, Kawthar El Chediak

• Rochester Institute of Technology, Dubai

Abstract

Public speaking anxiety (PSA) is one of the most prevalent forms of anxiety and associated with significant academic, occupational and social impairment. Systematic exposure therapy with VR has proven to be an effective treatment for anxiety disorders; however, there are limited studies to date that have investigated the effect of the length of time spent on individualized Virtual Reality Systematic Desensitization (VRSD) on treatment effectiveness. The purpose of this study is to assess the effectiveness of a 4-session VRSD intervention as compared to a separate 8-session VRSD study with similar intervention and evaluation procedures.

Methods: Participants with self-reported public speaking anxiety will be randomly divided into two groups — one receiving the 4-session intervention and the other receiving the 8-session intervention. The pre- and post- Public Speaking Anxiety Scale (PSAS), Generalized Anxiety Disorder-7 (GAD-7), Subjective Units of Distress Scale (SUDS) and biological measures of heart rate, skin conductance and body temperature will be compared. The VRSD protocol includes a personalized fear hierarchy, virtual reality exposure, relaxation, and biofeedback. Both interventions use the same VR scenarios at the same intensity.

Hypothesis: It is hypothesized that both protocols will result in the same amount of reduction in PSA symptoms as measured by PSAS, GAD-7 and SUDS.

Conclusion: A comparison of outcomes between intervention durations may offer a preliminary guide to the importance of treatment duration for VRSD of PSA, and inform the creation of personally tailored VR-based interventions for university students.

Digital Wellbeing in the Social Media Era: Understanding Social Media Detoxification in Adults

12:00-14:00

Sherine Bou Dargham (The Valens Clinic, King's College London), Lara Daouk (The Valens Clinic), Rama Kanj (The Valens Clinic, University of Reading)

• The Valens Clinic

Abstract

Social media has become an increasingly prominent part of everyday life, and concerns surrounding its problematic use and implications for mental health have become an important area of research. Problematic use has been associated with lower self-esteem, depressive symptoms, and sleep disturbance. In response, social media detoxification (SMD), defined as a temporary break from social media, has emerged as a strategy for promoting healthier digital engagement. However, evidence regarding its effects on wellbeing remains mixed.

In a previous study, we developed a scale to explore the characteristics of SMD in university students. At the time, this was one of the earliest attempts to systematically investigate SMD among university students. Our findings indicated considerable variability among those who engaged in SMD in terms of detox duration, perceived improvements, platforms abstained from, and gender. This is consistent with recent research, with some studies reporting small but positive effects of SMD on wellbeing, while others suggest that it may have adverse effects.

Here, we revisit our original findings in the context of this expanding evidence and provide an overview of what is currently known about SMD, its potential benefits and limitations, and factors that may influence its effectiveness. Building on this work, we propose a larger-scale investigation of SMD among university students, examining individual differences, motivations, and patterns of detoxification. We will also introduce a complementary questionnaire under development examining parents' awareness and perception of technology and social media use among children, extending our research into digital wellbeing across developmental stages.

The Influence of Emotion Regulation Strategies on Obsessive-Compulsive Symptom Dimensions Among University Students

12:00-14:00

Eden Elsa Luis, Maliha Masood (Co-author), Dr. Anita Shrivastava Kashi (Co-author)

• Middlesex University Dubai

Abstract

Obsessive-compulsive Symptom Dimensions (OCSD) are severely distressing and prevalent in non-clinical populations. A noteworthy factor contributing to OCSD is Emotional Regulation (ER) and its strategies, cognitive reappraisal and expressive suppression. Previous research has examined ER strategies in clinical, situational, or experimental settings; less is known about how trait-level tendencies toward ER strategies relate to OCSD in non-clinical university student populations. The present study hypothesized that ER would significantly predict OCSD of contamination, responsibility for harm and mistakes, symmetry/incompleteness, and unacceptable thoughts. A quantitative, within-group study design was adopted. Three hundred and one largely Asian university students aged 18 years and above were recruited through convenience sampling. Emotional regulation was assessed with the ER Questionnaire, and OCSD were measured with the Dimensional Obsessive-Compulsive Scale. Four multiple regressions were conducted to analyse the impact of cognitive reappraisal and expressive suppression on OCSD. Cognitive reappraisal emerged as a significant negative predictor of all OCSD, while expressive suppression was a positive predictor of contamination only. Expressive suppression did not significantly predict responsibility for harm and mistakes, symmetry/incompleteness, or unacceptable thoughts. The results suggest that ER strategies may have a stable, significant impact on OCSD characteristics when embedded as trait-like tendencies. It assists professionals in forming interventions for university students to engage in adaptive ER. Recommendations for future research include the formulation of OCD-specific ER measures for university student populations and accounting for cultural differences as a demographic variable.

Exploring University Students' Subjective Experiences and Emotions when Interacting with AI

12:00-14:00

Fathima Hanah Kiyas Ali, Miss Sarentha Luther (Supervisor)

• De Montfort University Dubai, Division of Psychology

Abstract

The ongoing rapid development and integration of artificial intelligence is transforming the current world; its simultaneously growing body of research is yet to address its emotional and experiential role in the lives of youth. Hence, the current study makes use of interpretive phenomenological analysis in order to gain a deeper understanding of the meanings, emotions and reflections that arise from college students' experiences with AI technologies in their everyday lives. A total of 8 participants from both the UK and the UAE, aged 18-20 years old, were individually interviewed about their perception of AI in their lives. A total of 5 group experiential teams were developed from the data, each with varying subthemes. Participants described conflicting ideals on the topic of AI, outlining the struggle of maintaining ethical use of such a controversial tool. They also described the regret and disappointment that result from use, the distress they feel as they watch AI change the world around them and the fear they feel as they watch AI impact the future of humanity. The results of the study contribute to a deeper understanding of the emotionally complex interplay between individuals and this novel technology, as well as provide implications for supporting young people through this stage of rapid change in society, highlighting their voices and their worries in a world they are soon to inherit.

Emotion Regulation and Healthcare-Seeking and Healthcare-Avoidance Behaviors Among Undergraduate Students in the United Arab Emirates

12:00-14:00

Areeba Ilyas, Anushka Naomi Daulagala, Ala Achour, Efthymios Papatzikis

• Canadian University Dubai, Dubai, United Arab Emirates

Abstract

Healthcare-seeking and healthcare-avoidance behaviors are important to understanding how students engage with healthcare. Whether students seek care or avoid it bears directly on whether those experiencing distress reach support, making these behaviors relevant to student mental health and wellbeing. In this study, an exploratory analysis found a small positive association between healthcare-seeking and healthcare-avoidance behaviors (Spearman's $\rho = .208$, $p = .035$), indicating that they do not represent opposite ends of a single dimension. This finding is consistent with the separate healthcare-seeking and healthcare-avoidance dimensions reported by the developers of the HCbQ.

This study examined whether emotion regulation strategies, specifically cognitive reappraisal and expressive suppression, were associated with healthcare-seeking and healthcare-avoidance behaviors among undergraduate students in the United Arab Emirates. Using a cross-sectional correlational design, 103 undergraduate students aged 18 or older were recruited through convenience and snowball sampling across UAE universities. Participants completed the Emotion Regulation Questionnaire (ERQ) and the Healthcare Behaviors Questionnaire (HCbQ). The study was reviewed and approved by the Canadian University Dubai Human Subjects Research Ethics Committee prior to data collection.

Contrary to the hypotheses, neither expressive suppression nor cognitive reappraisal was significantly associated with healthcare-seeking or healthcare-avoidance behaviors (all $p > .29$). Emotion regulation variables explained minimal variance in these behaviors ($R\text{-squared} \leq .024$).

Overall, the findings provide limited support for dispositional emotion regulation as an explanatory factor in healthcare-seeking and healthcare-avoidance behaviors. Future research should employ longitudinal and multimethod designs to clarify determinants of students' healthcare decision-making.

The Role of Mental Health, Resilience, and Social Engagement in Academic Performance: A Multi-Campus, Cross-Cultural Perspective

12:00-14:00

Mini Parvathi Santhosh, Anushua Biswas, Rupa Kalahasthi

• Rochester Institute of Technology, Dubai

Abstract

University life often includes early adulthood challenges that strain mental health through academic, social, and personal demands. Anxiety (32.1%) and depression (28.9%) are prevalent among college students worldwide, along with varying levels of stress, with risk factors such as social isolation contributing to poor mental health, while protective factors such as resilience may help students manage these challenges. Poor mental health has also been linked to declining academic performance, as difficulties with motivation, focus, and cognitive function affect students' academic performance, thus resulting in a cyclic relationship where mental health and academic performance are closely connected. Findings on this relationship remain inconsistent across cultural contexts: mental health symptoms did not significantly predict academic performance among Spanish students, while studies from students in Canada and Japan found strong predictive effects. This inconsistency suggests that cultural and institutional context may shape how mental health relates to academic performance. This study examines how mental health affects academic performance among university students across global campuses and tests whether social engagement and resilience moderate this association, using a quantitative, correlation survey-based design, thus offering insight from a multi-campus, cross-cultural perspective on how these factors shape student wellbeing across culturally diverse populations.